

Radiant Soma

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1 PROJECT URL

<https://augmentedmaterialitylab.org/2021/11/22/soma/>

2 DESCRIPTION OF ARTWORK

The human body has historically been a constant source of fascination in the arts and sciences. With the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic, the debate over the virtues and disadvantages of physical versus virtual bodies has increased dramatically. One of the most difficult attributes of the human body to translate into other forms is the essence of human movement and, by extension, energy. *Radiant Soma* emphasizes the ephemerality of human movement by visualizing motion capture data with light. The installation of lasers and phosphorescent objects transforms choreography that the original performer can no longer perform into a constant stream of lively spirits.



Radiant Soma began as a philosophical conjecture on how a machine might visualize its own body based on its understanding of

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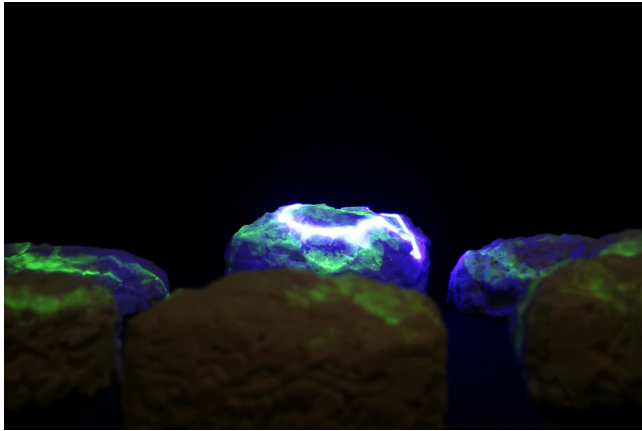
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human somatic movement practices. Lasers were the most appropriate method for translating from digital data into the physical realm as it is simultaneously tangible and malleable. A proof-of-concept to test the interplay between movement and light was then developed using motion capture data of the choreographic work *Oncheon*. The mocap data held special significance for two reasons. First, it combined the structure of *salpuri*, a traditional Korean shamanic dance to expel spirits, with contemporary dance and somatic movement. Second, *Oncheon* was performed and recorded despite triggering severe chronic pain and fatigue. It is unlikely that it can ever be performed again by the original choreographer/performer.



To further reinforce the concept of spirits and embodied memories, we drew inspiration from Stone Tape Theory for the projection surfaces. One interpretation of Stone Tape Theory is that objects such as rocks are capable of absorbing and replaying the traces of human thoughts and emotions. In *Radiant Soma*, the emotionally-driven motion is projected onto phosphorescent “stones” that temporarily record and display the traces in a visible way. These traces slowly fade over time allowing viewers to contemplate the simultaneous beauty and temporality of movement and light. The process of recording and disappearing also recalls a key element of *salpuri*, which is the expelling of negative energy. On a conceptual level, the stones help strip away the negative memories embedded in the mocap data by retaining only the purest aspects of the movement.



3 ARTIST INFORMATION

Jayson Haebich is an artist, developer, and researcher based in Hong Kong who works with lighting technologies. He has presented work worldwide including at the Salisbury Cathedral, Bauhaus, Somerset House, British Film Institute, and in smaller galleries and institutions across Europe, Australia and China.

Eugenia S. Kim is a Korean-American transdisciplinary creator and researcher who uses movement and multimedia technology to create narratives and visualizations. Her research uses dance and somatic movement practices, motion capture, virtual reality (VR) and metaverse platforms to create illness narratives.

Alvaro Cassinelli is head of the Augmented Materiality Lab at the School of Creative Media, City University of Hong Kong. He has received Honorary Mention at Ars Electronica, Grand Prize [Art Division] at the 9th Japan Media Art Festival, and the Excellence Prize [Entertainment Division] at the 13th Japan Media Art Festival among other prestigious honors.

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Motion capture data for *Oncheon* recorded at the Centre For Transformative Media Technologies, Swinburne University of Technology, Melbourne, Australia with direction and dramaturgy assistance provided by Professor Kim Vincs and Dr. John McCormick.